ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 112: Comparative Traditions of World Theatres

Compare performance traditions without ranking them

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Comparison is a skill, not a list. This pack gives you a comparison grid covering space, performer training, text, audience and purpose, then applies it to African festival theatre, Greek theatre, Noh, Commedia dell'arte and contemporary Nigerian stage practice.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Construct a comparison grid for any two performance traditions.
- Describe Greek, Japanese and African traditions using accurate terminology.
- Explain how performer training and audience expectation differ across traditions.
- Avoid evolutionist language that treats one tradition as more advanced.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Compare on dimensions, not vibes

A comparison needs fixed criteria applied to both cases.

- Space: where does performance happen, and who can see whom?
- Text: is there a fixed script, an outline, or an inherited pattern?
- Performer: trained specialist, community member, or both?
- Audience: separated, participating, or paying customers?
- Purpose: civic competition, religious observance, entertainment or social critique?
- Transmission: school, apprenticeship, family lineage or mass media?

> **Do not write 'primitive'**
> Evolutionist language - primitive to sophisticated - is inaccurate and penalised. Say 'participatory' or 'text-centred' and define it.

Three traditions in brief

Know enough detail to support a comparison, not a full history.

- Greek: civic festival of Dionysus, masked actors, chorus, open-air amphitheatre, competition between playwrights.
- Japanese Noh: highly codified movement, masks, chant and a slow tempo; transmission through schools and lineages.
- African festival theatre: community participation, music and dance as structure, flexible performance space.
- Commedia dell'arte: professional troupes, stock characters, improvisation around a scenario, touring economy.
- Nigerian contemporary stage: blends festival elements, literary drama and popular theatre forms.

Writing the comparison answer

Structure carries the marks.

1. Introduce both traditions with dates and contexts.
2. State the criteria you will compare on.
3. Take one criterion at a time and discuss both cases.
4. Give a specific example for each claim.
5. Explain a similarity and a difference in function, not only in appearance.
6. Conclude with what the comparison reveals about theatre as a human practice.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 112

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 112 Comparative Traditions of World Theatres appears in the 2018 course descriptions
- The same page separates THA 113 Theatre History in Perspective: 500 BC - 1800 AD
- Descriptions emphasise comparison of world traditions rather than a single national history

What changed: THA 113 appears in the 2018 description but is absent from the 2019 programme listing, so the history sequence was reorganised.

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 112 Comparative Traditions of World Theatres, 3 credits, second semester, 100 level
- Second-semester 100-level package includes THA 122, 132, 142, 152 and 162
- No THA 113 in this listing

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Comparative traditions remains a 100-level core in the compiled map
- Expect African, Asian and European traditions to be compared rather than surveyed separately
- Check whether your cohort takes this in first or second semester

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. List five dimensions for comparing performance traditions.

Answer: Space, text, performer training, audience role and purpose. Transmission is a sixth.

2. What makes Noh a useful comparison with Greek theatre?

Answer: Both use masks, highly formalised performance and inherited conventions, but differ in tempo, competition and religious framing.

3. Why is 'primitive theatre' an inaccurate phrase?

Answer: It imposes a false hierarchy of development and ignores the sophistication and function of participatory forms.

4. How does audience role differ between festival theatre and proscenium theatre?

Answer: Festival audiences participate and may be part of the performance; proscenium audiences are separated and typically observe.

5. What is a scenario in Commedia dell'arte?

Answer: An outline of situations and stock characters that performers develop through improvisation rather than a fixed script.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a comparison grid with six dimensions.
- [ ] Fill the grid for two traditions you have studied.
- [ ] Learn ten terms specific to non-European theatre.
- [ ] Watch a short Noh excerpt and note three conventions.
- [ ] Write a 400-word comparison with evidence for each claim.
- [ ] Remove every evolutionist phrase from your draft.
- [ ] Discuss your grid with a coursemate and add one dimension you missed.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Theatre & Film Studies | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

THA 112: Comparative Traditions of World Theatres